

Sin Has Lost Its Dominion

One thing I am coming to appreciate about the Holy Spirit is that He does more than impart revelation knowledge. That is the attribute I used to appreciate most. But if you have ever had Him step in and help you worship, you know there are other attributes just as precious.

Hallelujah. Glory be to God.

Paul speaks to the Jewish community in Rome:

"I speak to them that know the law."

He explains that the law does not save. By the law was the knowledge of sin. The Jew was struggling to understand why Gentiles could receive the same inheritance without keeping the law.

Paul says that if the uncircumcised Gentile, by the new nature, keeps what is contained in the law, does that not count as circumcision? And if the Jew, circumcised by nature, does not keep the law, does that not become uncircumcision?

The part of the law in view is the Ten Commandments, which describe the new nature. The law revealed sin, but the new nature can finally fulfill the righteousness the law described.

Romans 6 deals with the two Adams and shows that both Jew and Gentile must be baptized into Jesus' death and resurrection. The old man must be destroyed, and the new nature received.

Then Romans 7 returns to the Jew's position under the law. Israel was married to God through the law while spiritually dead. That was impossible, because God required them to keep commandments they had no nature to keep.

Romans 7:5 says:

"For when we were in the flesh,
the motions of sins, which were by the law,
did work in our members to bring forth fruit unto death."

The law said, "Thou shalt not," and the death nature produced fruit. The commandment exposed what spiritual death was.

Romans 7:6 says:

"But now we are delivered from the law,
that being dead wherein we were held;
that we should serve in newness of spirit,
and not in the oldness of the letter."

The old man was crucified with Christ. Yet I live, but not I; Christ lives in me. The old man was destroyed, and it was that spiritually dead man the law held.

Now that he is dead, the Jew is freed from the law to marry another, even Him who is risen from the dead. That union brings forth fruit unto God: newness of life.

Romans 7:7 says:

"What shall we say then?
Is the law sin?
God forbid.
Nay, I had not known sin,
but by the law:
for I had not known lust,
except the law had said,
Thou shalt not covet."

How could a spiritually dead man know anything outside his own nature? The law came and commanded him to stop. Then the nature he had produced fruit contrary to God.

Sin took occasion by the commandment and produced all manner of concupiscence. Without the law, sin was dead because it was unresisted. The commandment revealed the old nature.

The law is holy, just, and good. It describes God's nature. But it made sin appear sinful by exposing what was already in the spiritually dead man.

Romans 7:18-24 says:

"For I know that in me (that is, in my flesh,) dwelleth no good thing...
For the good that I would I do not:
but the evil which I would not, that I do...
I find then a law,
that, when I would do good,
evil is present with me...
O wretched man that I am!
who shall deliver me from the body of this death?"

Paul is describing the law of sin in the members, warring against the law of the mind and bringing the man into captivity. With his mind, he wants to serve God. But the death nature is stronger.

Then Paul answers:

"I thank God through Jesus Christ our Lord."

Romans 8:1 says:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,
who walk not after the flesh,
but after the Spirit."

This means there are no more condemning sentences under the judicial system of the law. The old spiritually dead man who received the law and could not keep it was condemned to death. But now I am in Christ Jesus. I no longer walk after the flesh, the unregenerated nature. I walk after the born-again spirit.

Paul already said in Romans 6 that sin shall not have dominion over you. Romans 7 breaks down why. Romans 8 announces the freedom.

John G. Lake understood this. During the bubonic plague, he and those he trained handled bodies and burned contaminated houses. The plague died on contact with his skin. When officials asked his secret, he answered with Romans 8:

"The law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus
hath made me free from the law of sin and death."

He knew that sickness, disease, poverty, and death had their roots in the fall. He knew the condemning sentences attached to spiritual death could not be carried out in him as he walked in the law of life.

The mark of a good teacher is that those who followed him walked in it too.

Romans 8:2 says:

"For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus
hath made me free from the law of sin and death."

The Spirit of life here is not first the Holy Spirit. It is the born-again human spirit possessing a new nature. The law connected with that new nature says you are free from the law of sin and death.

If you make this only the Holy Spirit, then you spend your life trying to get Him to do something for you. But if this is your new nature, then the freedom is already yours. The Holy Spirit comes to enforce and help what Christ has made you.

There is a world of difference between trying to get something done and yielding to what has already been done.

Some say, "My spirit is already all-knowing and strong; only my soul needs renewing." Your soul does need renewing, but your soul will never carry more power than your spirit. If your soul continually dominates, your spirit needs to be taught and strengthened.

Finding out that my spirit needed to go from glory to glory changed my life.

Second Corinthians says:

"Cleansing ourselves from all filthiness of the flesh and spirit,
perfecting holiness in the fear of God."

There can be wrong believing in the spirit. The Holy Spirit brings your born-again spirit forward through praying in tongues, worship, and meditating the Word relentlessly.

Whenever Romans 8 says "not after the flesh but after the Spirit," Paul is dividing between the old covenant and sonship. He is acting like a lawyer and arguing for your freedom.

Romans 7:5 defines "in the flesh":

"For when we were in the flesh,
the motions of sins, which were by the law,
did work in our members to bring forth fruit unto death."

So "after the flesh" means after the unregenerated nature under law, not merely having a bad morning.

Romans 8:3-4 says:

"For what the law could not do,
in that it was weak through the flesh,
God sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh,
and for sin, condemned sin in the flesh:
That the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us,
who walk not after the flesh,
but after the Spirit."

The righteousness of the law can finally be fulfilled in those who walk after the new nature.

Romans 8:5 says:

"For they that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh;
but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit."

The spiritually dead man has his mind brought into captivity to the death nature. He minds the things of the flesh because he has no other freedom.

But the born-again man can have his mind brought under the new nature. His reasoning can be liberated to follow God.

That alone is enough to make the journey to heaven with victory over sin. But God also gave us the Holy Ghost for power, teaching, and help.

Romans 8:13-14 says:

"For if ye live after the flesh,
ye shall die:
but if ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body,
ye shall live.
For as many as are led by the Spirit of God,
they are the sons of God."

Through the new nature, you mortify the deeds of the body. The new nature supplies life to bring any remaining deeds of the body to a dead standstill.

Being led by the Spirit here is being led out of the old bondage by the new nature into sonship. The Holy Spirit also comes to minister the rights of that new nature, but first Paul wants you to know you are free.

Romans 8:6-8 says:

"For to be carnally minded is death;
but to be spiritually minded is life and peace.
Because the carnal mind is enmity against God:
for it is not subject to the law of God,
neither indeed can be.
So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God."

The carnal mind is the mind under the captivity of the death nature. It is not subject to the law of God and cannot be.

This is positional truth. It is not simply saying you had a bad day and got in the flesh. Paul is describing the unregenerated state.

Then he says:

"But ye are not in the flesh,
but in the Spirit,
if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you."

You are not in the flesh because you have been born again.

Romans 8:9-11 continues speaking of the born-again spirit, the spirit that is of Christ. If any man does not have the Spirit of Christ, he is none of His.

The first clear mention of the Holy Spirit in Romans 8 is verse 16:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit,
that we are the children of God."

The Holy Spirit steps in and bears witness with your born-again spirit: "That is your Father."

He is your Teacher, but He reveals one Teacher: Christ. We are only teachers under the one Teacher. If we are not revealing what the Holy Spirit reveals, we stop short.